

Session 2: The Abraham Story as a Whole

Key Takeaways

- The biblical narrative contains only certain events from the lives of Avraham and Sarah. The biblical authors select specific events to communicate an intentional message.
- The biblical authors design the text in symmetrically arranged sections, often in groups of three, to help readers make connections, comparisons, and contrasts.

The Macro Design of Genesis 11:27-25:18

Genesis 11:27-19:38

From Babylon to Hebron and Sodom

11:27-14:24

- **11:27-12:5** From Babylon to Canaan
- **12:6-13:18** From Canaan to Egypt back to Canaan
- **14:1-24** Avram rescues Lot from Babylonian alliance

15:1-17:27

- **15:1-21** Avram's faith and the covenant
- **16:1-16** The failure with Hagar
- **17:1-27** Circumcision and the covenant renewed

18:1-19:38

- **18:1-15** Avram and Sarah promised a son
- **18:16-33** Avram intercedes for Lot in Sodom
- **19:1-39** Lot is rescued out of Sodom's ruin

Genesis 20:1-22:19

From Sodom and Hebron to Mount Moriah

20:1-18

Avraham Deceives Avimelek About Sarah

- 20:1-2
- 20:3-13
- 20:14-18

21:1-21:34

- **21:1-21** Yitskhaq born and separated from Hagar and Yishmael
- **21:22-34** Avraham and Avimelek united through covenant

22:1-19

Avraham Loses and Regains Yitskhaq

- 22:1-3
- 22:4-14
- 22:15-19

Genesis 22:20-25:18

From Mount Moriah to Mesopotamia and Back Again

22:20-24

Rivqah Born in Mesopotamia

- 22:20-22
- 22:23
- 22:24

23:1-20

Sarah Dies and Is Buried

- 23:1-2
- 23:3-16
- 23:17-20

24:1-67

Rivqah's Journey from Mesopotamia to Canaan

- 24:1-28
- 24:29-51
- 24:52-67

25:1-18

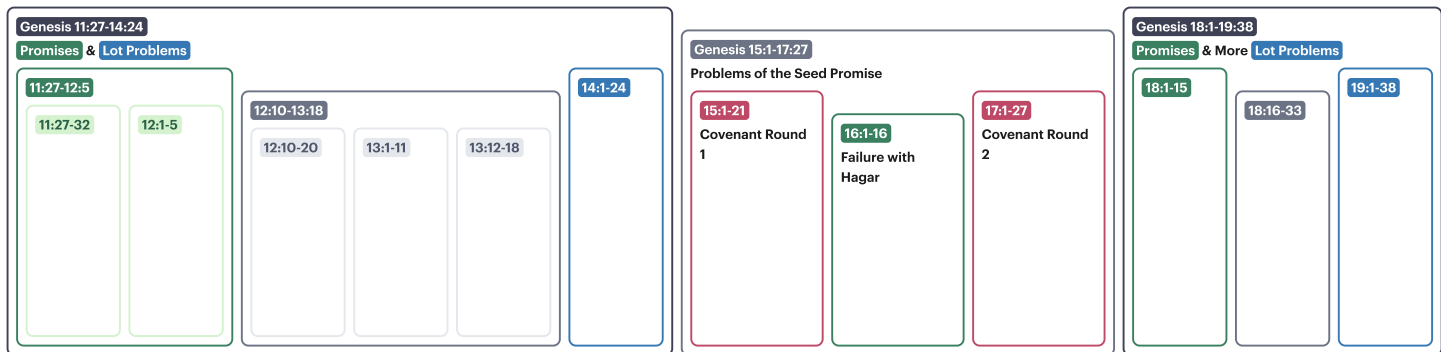
Avraham Dies and Is Buried

- 25:1-6
- 25:7-11
- 25:12-18

Genesis 11:27-25:18. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

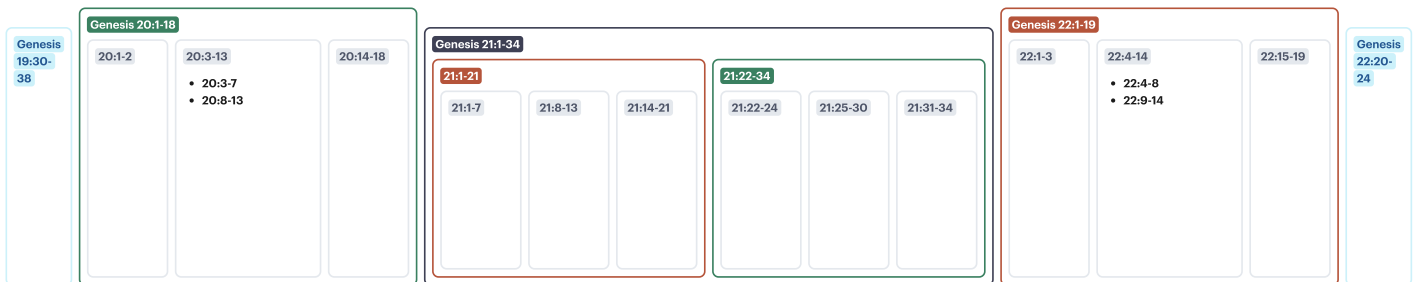
The Literary Organization of the Avraham Story Visualized

From Mesopotamia to Hebron and Sodom



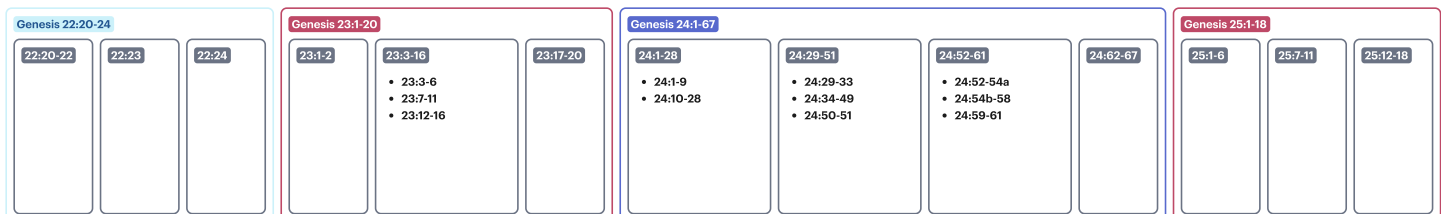
Genesis 11:27-19:38. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

From Sodom and Hebron to Mount Moriah



Genesis 20:1-22:24. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

From Mount Moriah to Mesopotamia and Back Again



Genesis 22:20-25:18. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Notice that each of these three movements is not aligned with our contemporary chapter numbers, and so a glance at the content of these literary divisions may seem counterintuitive. This is primarily due to the fact

that the literary organization of the Avraham story is patterned after the literary organization of Genesis 1:1-11:26, both in its design and in the main themes explored in the narratives. So to truly grasp what the Avraham story is about, we need to recap the story so far as it's presented in Genesis 1-11.

Reflection Question

How does the analogy of the arranged potted plants help us understand the conventions of biblical literature?